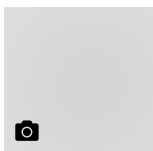
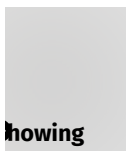


https://www.applevalleynewsnow.com/news/walla-walla-police-end-flock-license-plate-cameras-over-safety-and-legal-concerns/article_ec96e8f8-a14e-43b3-b6b2-7d53846dd659.html

Walla Walla police end Flock license plate cameras over safety and legal concerns

William Albert, Apple Valley News Now
Jan 7, 2026



The Brief

- Walla Walla Police Department shut down Flock Safety camera program this month after court ruling made all images public record
- Flood of disclosure requests overwhelmed staff and created legal liability when images were automatically deleted after 30 days
- Police raised serious safety concerns the system could be misused by stalkers or private investigators to track victims

WALLA WALLA, Wash. — Walla Walla police have ended their use of Flock license plate cameras after safety and legal concerns began to outweigh the benefits of the automatic license plate reader system.

The Walla Walla Police Department shut down the Flock Safety camera program this month after a court ruling made all images public record, sparking a flood of disclosure requests that overwhelmed staff, created legal liability when images were automatically deleted after 30 days, and raised serious safety concerns the system could be misused by stalkers or private investigators to track victims.

The decision represents a significant shift for the department, which had been using the cameras to help solve crimes and recover stolen vehicles. The automatic license plate readers captured images of vehicles on public roadways and stored them for 30 days before deletion.

"So our cameras are not active — they are not taking pictures — and at some point Flock is going to show up and take their cameras back," said Nick Loudermilk, Administrative Sergeant with the Walla Walla Police Department.

The court ruling that made Flock images subject to public disclosure created unexpected challenges for the police department. What was intended as a law enforcement tool became accessible to anyone making public records requests, fundamentally changing how the system operated.

The automatic 30-day deletion schedule, originally designed as a privacy protection, became a legal liability when combined with public disclosure requirements. Staff found themselves unable to fulfill legitimate records requests when images were deleted before they could be processed, creating potential lawsuit exposure.

The flood of disclosure requests strained department resources as staff struggled to process the volume of requests while maintaining other essential functions. The administrative burden became unsustainable for a department already managing multiple responsibilities.

Safety concerns emerged as officials realized the system could be exploited by individuals seeking to harm others. Stalkers and private investigators could potentially use public records requests to obtain location information about victims, turning a crime-fighting tool into a potential weapon for harassment.

The automatic nature of the cameras meant they captured images of all vehicles, including those of domestic violence victims, witnesses in sensitive cases, and others who might be at risk if their movements were tracked. The public disclosure requirements eliminated protections for vulnerable individuals.

Police officials determined that the risks to public safety from potential misuse outweighed the law enforcement benefits the system provided. The decision prioritized protecting potential victims over maintaining an investigative tool that could be exploited.

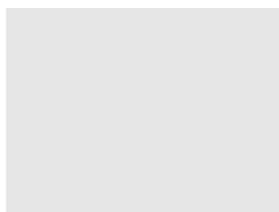
The situation illustrates the complex challenges law enforcement agencies face when implementing new technologies. Tools designed to enhance public safety can create unintended consequences when combined with transparency requirements and public access laws.

The Flock system had proven effective for legitimate law enforcement purposes, helping officers locate stolen vehicles and investigate crimes. However, the unintended accessibility created risks that officials deemed unacceptable.

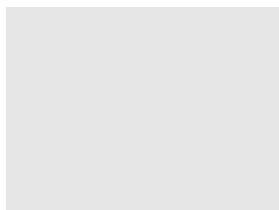
The department's experience highlights the need for careful consideration of how new technologies interact with existing legal frameworks. Public disclosure laws designed to ensure government transparency can have unexpected effects when applied to automated surveillance systems.

Police say public safety and community trust ultimately drove the decision to end the program. The department chose to eliminate a useful investigative tool rather than risk enabling harassment or stalking through the public records process.

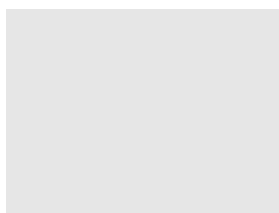
The cameras will be removed by Flock Safety, ending the department's participation in the license plate reader program. Officials emphasized that protecting community members from potential harm took precedence over maintaining law enforcement capabilities that could be misused.



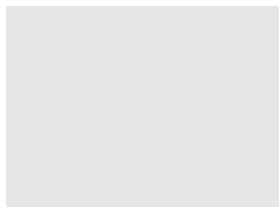
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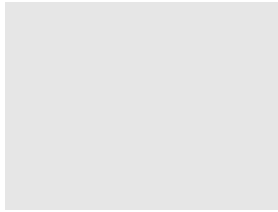


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